

... this place sure has deteriorated beyond all possible expectations. Somehow it feels like I just got out of a coma—plucked out of it and put right back on the street knowing I'd been in a coma but not for how long, trying to guess from the available evidence, but disappointed and confused to find that time and place no longer really seem to function here, not as I know them. All signs of the alteration have been frozen in renovations eternally clean, pasty, unmoving. Like the vital needs of energy and movement have been outsourced elsewhere, or like they discovered cryogenics for cities before people. Hell, maybe I'm just having a stroke. Honestly, much of the time these days you'd hardly notice.

I first moved here in 2001 after finding a room on Craigslist. It was in an old coach house on a narrow side street. The ad—for a roommate, posted by the other prospective tenant—didn't bullshit about the derelict condition. Rent was very cheap, especially with the two of us. There were lingering notes of horse shit even though the horses were long gone, obviously. The mice drew a regular crowd of neighbourhood cats who seemed to prefer ours over their owners' company. The floors slanted up like the deck of a sailboat tacking against a strong wind, probably due more to the renovations—a species of pernicious incompetence—than the original structure, which was solid. We had to adapt, correct our bodies' inherent biases toward the straight and level.

The only level floor space in the coach house was in a corner of the bedroom on the ground floor, technically mine, though after a while we tended to skulk about somewhat like the cats between houses. That was because Dave kept his flatscreen TV there in the flat corner. It was a Samsung, large and rectilinear and monolithically black like nothing else in the dilapidated house, hence very incongruous. Neither of us could have afforded a thing like that then at market price. Dave worked as a busboy at Filmores across town, claimed he'd gotten it from a biker in exchange for a day's labour. Personally, I wouldn't have trusted Dave then if I'd thought I had anything to lose by it.

Dave and I were both 18 then and new to Toronto. We had our preconceptions from movies like *Crash* and *Exotica*—all false of course, a city being something that needs to be repeatedly

guessed at and projected upon, whether because of a vitality which largely eludes or because it leaves so much to be desired or both. Either way, the individual has to make it up for themselves, while these foreign investors come and jack up the property values.

But we also had our impressions from having spent a good part of the 90s watching MuchMusic on TV. Before then, the TV screen had been such an overtly remote, passive thing, for decompressing, coming down from the hazards of lived experience. Until MuchMusic came along with its live-air, street-level programming. The pinnacle for the young teenager being the rare moments when somebody showed their tits or talked about how paranoid and horny they were before they could be live-edited out. All carefully cultivated and baked into the production, I have to assume. A few years downstream of MTV, effectively a cultural propaganda platform serving up certain Toronto-based versions of music and culture to the nation's youth. Still, it allured with the sense of a new format developing more or less in realtime, thus inevitably infused with doses of chaos, risking some level of compounded exposure to the city's seedy diffusions, however pre-programmed the leakage. And the people no doubt gave it what they learned to want from it, with teenagers in the background daring each other to show things they imagined couldn't be unseen.

Definitely touched on some limit to the medium many probably dreamed of surpassing. In this it was not the first, but it was definitely a timely catalyst. By the time I moved to Toronto, the station had long ago veered back toward the dominant tendencies of the medium rather than somehow figuring out a way of expanding or renewing its sense of the unscripted, exposed, interactive. Not that it ever really inspired an expectation of the reverse, despite its suggestiveness. Walking back from those limits was, of course, the beginning of the end. And now, there's not even any sun-bleaching around the area the sign used to occupy. It has in fact been replaced by something fully sanitized, bereft of life, hardly situated in time and space at all. I can at least say that its absence is felt.

Incidentally, one day I came home from work and Dave had dismantled the flatscreen, carefully, methodically, keeping all its component parts—from the screen and casing to the tiniest

screw—clean, intact and well-organized. It was as if he was simply looking for something hidden in there, I dared not ask what, and expected to reassemble it all after having found it. Dead tired, I simply went up to his room to sleep. The next morning I was awakened by him asking me to help haul the improbably reconfigured mass of the television up the stairs to his bedroom. I did so, and from then on we again stuck to our separate rooms.